

CODE OF LAW

King Hammurabi of Babylon laid down a set of strict rules that is one of the oldest recorded codes of law in the world.



NO RUNAWAYS
If you helped a slave to run away, you would be put to death.



HANDS OFF!
If a son hit his father, his hands would be chopped off.



TEMPLE OF DOOM
If you stole from a temple, you would be sentenced to death.

INVENTION OF THE WHEEL

Nobody knows exactly when the wheel was invented, but they were in use in Sumer by 3500 BCE. Sumerians used the wheel vertically on their chariots, and horizontally to make clay pots.

RECONSTRUCTION OF AN EARLY WHEEL

DAILY LIFE

Cups, bowls, and vases for everyday use were made of clay, but richer homes used vessels made of stone or metal. Silver was imported from nearby Anatolia to make luxury tableware.



BRONZE BULL'S HEAD



SILVER BOWL



STONE POT



ALABASTER VASE



SOAPSTONE TUMBLER



SCORPION DESIGN CUP



CYLINDER SEAL (LEFT) WITH IMPRESSION (RIGHT) OF GODS FIGHTING LIONS

GODS AND RELIGION

The Sumerians worshipped many gods, but the most important were the guardians of each city-state. Gods were worshipped in huge temples called ziggurats, which dominated the flat landscape for miles.



UTU
God of the Sun and of justice.



ENLIL
God of wind and storms.

EARLY WRITING

The first known form of writing comes from Sumer. The first symbols were recognizable pictures of objects (pictograms), but these developed into a system of simpler wedge shapes, called cuneiform.

PICTOGRAPH c.3100 BCE	CUNEIFORM c.700 BCE
WATER	
HAND	
BARLEY	
BREAD	
DAY	

WEALTH AND POWER

Much of the Mesopotamian art and crafts that survives today was found in a royal cemetery in the city of Ur. These treasures tell us about the skill and artistry of the craftsmen who made them, as well as the wealth of the people buried with their valuable possessions.



QUEEN PUABI'S FINERY



SILVER HAIR COMB

FLY MOTIF NECKLACE



BEAD BELT

"RAM IN A THICKET"
Gold, silver, shell, and lapis ram and shrub.

WAR AND WARRIORS

The different city-states of Mesopotamia competed with one another for land and vital resources, such as water, and this often led to fighting and war. Warring cities began to organize trained groups of men to fight – the world's first armies. Soldiers wore bronze or leather helmets, and carried large shields and bronze spears or bows and arrows.



ARCHERS ON A CHARIOT